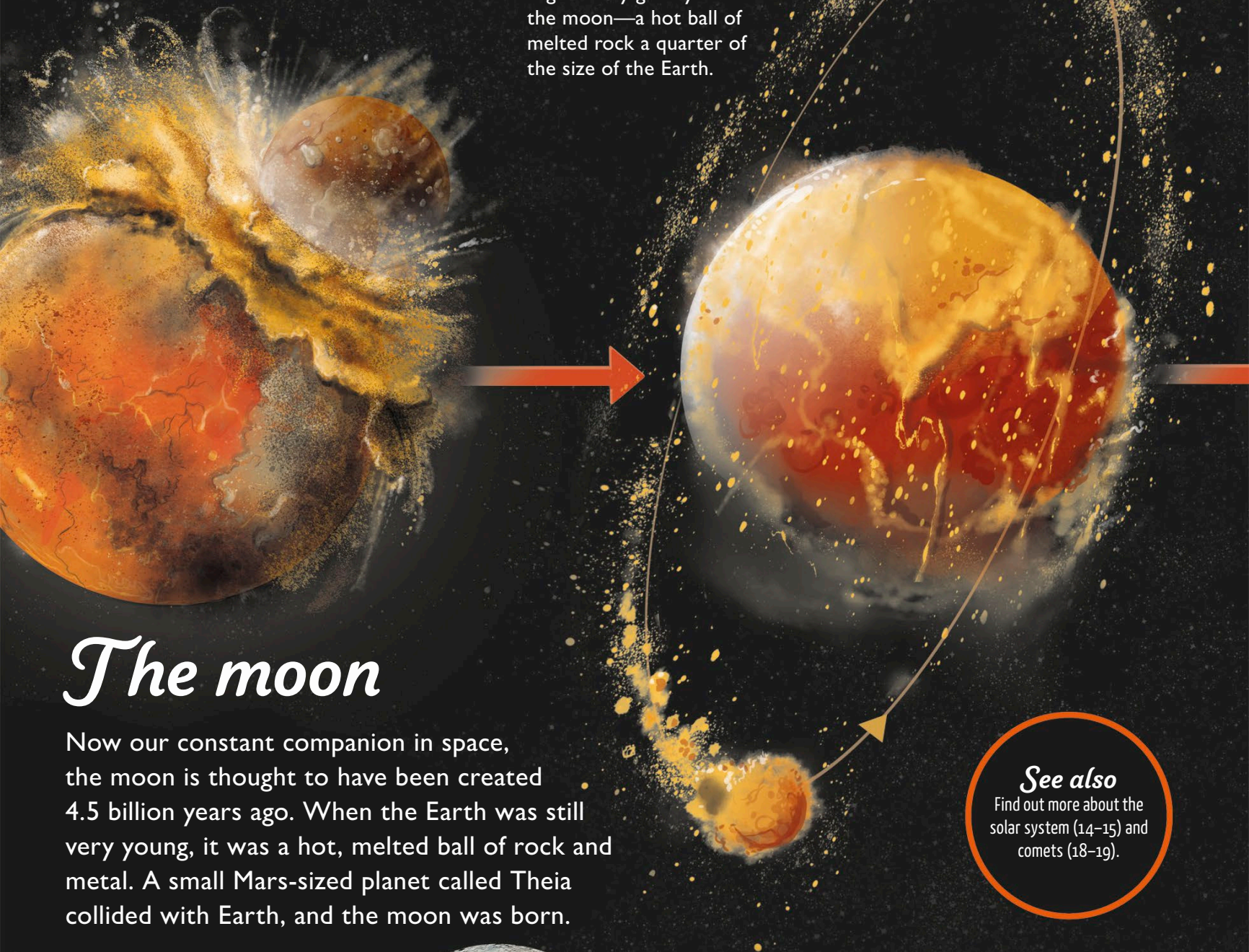


Collision in space

The collision with Earth destroyed Theia. Huge amounts of material from both planets were thrown into space. Melted rock from Theia combined with the Earth.

Forming the moon

The material from this collision was spun out into orbit around the Earth. Then it began to be pulled together by gravity to form the moon—a hot ball of melted rock a quarter of the size of the Earth.



The moon

Now our constant companion in space, the moon is thought to have been created 4.5 billion years ago. When the Earth was still very young, it was a hot, melted ball of rock and metal. A small Mars-sized planet called Theia collided with Earth, and the moon was born.

See also
Find out more about the solar system (14–15) and comets (18–19).

Lunar seas The side of the moon that faces us is covered in dark areas, or “seas”—so called because early astronomers thought they were real seas! They were formed about a billion years ago when melted rock, called magma, rose up to the surface and cooled.



Eclipse Sometimes, the sun, moon, and Earth are perfectly aligned so that as the moon passes between the sun and Earth, it is just the right size to perfectly cover (eclipse) the sun.

